

# The Hong Kong Polytechnic University

## Subject Description Form

*Please read the notes at the end of the table carefully before completing the form.*

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| <b>Subject Code</b>                                                 | ENGL1FN17                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Subject Title</b>                                                | The Art of Debate: Mastering Arguments to Help You Defeat Your Opponent                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Credit Value</b>                                                 | 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Level</b>                                                        | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Pre-requisite /<br/>Co-requisite/<br/>Exclusion</b>              | None.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Objectives</b>                                                   | <p>This subject engages students in debate as an active means through which to explore the critical thinking skills and logical structures that guide effective argumentation. As citizens of a globalized, hyper-connected world, we are exposed on a daily basis to a flood of information, misinformation, and biased reporting of diverse origins. A familiarity with the fundamentals of argumentation heightens our ability to evaluate the validity of the claims disseminated by these sources. In this course, students gain experience both constructing logically sound arguments and critically evaluating the arguments of others through a lively, motivating medium that brings friendly competition into the classroom. Applicable to a wide range of academic pursuits, the skills highlighted in this course are relevant to Poly U students enrolled in different disciplines. Moreover, acquisition of the key concepts of this course will support students' intellectual growth in their chosen field.</p> |
| <b>Intended Learning Outcomes</b><br><i>(Note 1)</i>                | <p>Upon completion of the subject, students will be able to:</p> <ol style="list-style-type: none"> <li>a. demonstrate familiarity with core principles of logic and critical thinking that shape effective arguments</li> <li>b. identify logical development of arguments and instances in which arguments have been weakened by logical fallacies</li> <li>c. apply effective argumentation strategies to a diverse range of debate topics</li> <li>d. construct compelling rebuttals to counter-arguments</li> <li>e. develop the ability to understand and respect opposing perspectives through the assignment of debate positions that deviate from students' own views</li> <li>f. apply their critical thinking and argumentation skills to their own fields of study</li> </ol>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Subject Synopsis/<br/>Indicative Syllabus</b><br><i>(Note 2)</i> | <p>The course is split up into two primary sections</p> <p><b>Analyzing the Argument</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• The Modes of Proof (week 1):<br/>-<i>Ethos</i></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |



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|                                      | <p>The subject is assessed through four modes:</p> <ol style="list-style-type: none"> <li>1.) A paper (approximately 1000-1500 words in length) in which students analyze an argument that is presented;</li> <li>2.) A debate in which student teams debate with other teams about assigned topics;</li> <li>3.) A test that assesses students' understanding of core theoretical concepts; and</li> <li>4.) Class participation in which students engage in class activities, reflect on their debate performance and prepare their arguments according to the topic as well as the highlighted theoretical concept.</li> </ol> <p>The course is designed to show direct connections between theory and its applications, and the assessments reflect this approach. Moreover, the authentic nature of the assessments allows students to simulate real-life contexts for practicing critical thinking skills; the feedback they receive from these assessments has the potential to inform the reasoning they apply to other academic and non-academic pursuits.</p> |          |
| <b>Student Study Effort Expected</b> | Class contact:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |          |
|                                      | ▪ Lectures                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | 26 Hrs.  |
|                                      | ▪ Seminars                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | 13 Hrs.  |
|                                      | Other student study effort:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |          |
|                                      | ▪ Preparation for lectures and seminars                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | 28 Hrs.  |
|                                      | ▪ Preparation for assessments                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | 52 Hrs.  |
|                                      | Total student study effort                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | 119 Hrs. |

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| <b>Reading List and References</b> | <p><b>Students are advised to purchase</b></p> <p>Hollihan, T. A., &amp; Baaske, K. T. (2016). <i>Arguments and arguing: The products and process of human decision-making</i> (3rd ed.). Waveland Press.</p> <p><b>Supplementary readings will be taken from the following texts:</b></p> <p>Dalton, P., &amp; Butler, J. R. (2015). Public policy argumentation and debate: A practical guide for advocacy. Peter Lang.</p> <p>Driscoll, W., &amp; Zompetti, J. P. (2003). <i>Discovering the world through debate</i>. International Debate Education Association.</p> <p>Freeley, A. J., &amp; Steinberg, D. L. (2014). <i>Argumentation and debate: Critical thinking for reasoned decision-making</i>. Wadsworth Cengage Learning.</p> <p>Johnson, S. L. (2009). <i>Winning debates: A guide to debating in the style of the world universities debating championships</i>. IDEBATE Press.</p> <p>Vancil, D. L. (1993). <i>Rhetoric and argumentation</i>. Simon and Schuster.</p> |
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Revised by Azar Tajabadi, July 2024